
When a Happy Worker is a Productive Worker: A Preliminary Examination of Three Models

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Abstract

The happy / productive worker thesis has long fascinated organizational scientists and practitioners alike. According to this thesis, happy employees exhibit higher levels of job-related performance behaviours than do unhappy employees. However, despite decades of study, support for this hypothesis remains equivocal. We propose that these inconsistent findings may be a consequence of the disparate manner in which happiness has been operationalized. To that end, the present two-year longitudinal field study provides the *first* opportunity to simultaneously examine the contributions of psychological well-being, job satisfaction and dispositional affect to job performance. While psychological well-being predicted job performance, the results failed to establish relations between job satisfaction and dispositional affect as predictors of job performance.

Résumé

La thèse du travailleur heureux/productif fascine depuis longtemps les scientifiques, tout comme les praticiens, de la psychologie organisationnelle. Selon cette thèse, l'employé heureux manifeste des niveaux de comportements liés à son emploi qui se rapprochent davantage des attentes que ne le font les employés malheureux. Or, malgré les études entreprises au cours des décennies, les éléments qui viennent corroborer cette thèse demeurent équivoques. Nous avançons que ces conclusions incompatibles avec l'hypothèse peuvent avoir été causées par la manière disparate d'opérationnaliser l'état du travailleur heureux. À cette fin, l'étude longitudinale sur le terrain de deux ans permet pour la première fois d'examiner simultanément comment le bien-être psychologique, la satisfaction professionnelle et l'affect de disposition jouent un rôle dans le rendement au travail. Bien que le bien-être psychologique permet de prédire le rendement au travail, les résultats ne permettent pas de démontrer des liens entre la satisfaction au travail et l'affect de disposition en tant qu'élément prévisionnel du rendement au travail.

At least since the seminal Hawthorne studies, the happy / productive worker thesis has intrigued both organizational scholars and practitioners alike. According to this hypothesis, "happy" workers demonstrate higher levels of job-related performance behaviours than do "unhappy" employees. Yet, despite the longevity of this debate, the veracity of the happy / productive worker thesis remains in doubt. Part of this confusion may result from the disparate manner in which happiness has been understood and measured (Wright & Cropanzano, 2000). While each of these perspectives has its merits, each may also house certain limitations. In the present two-year longitudinal field study, we investigated the contribution of job satisfaction, two measures of dispositional affect – positive and negative affectivity – and psychological well-being as predictors of job performance. We begin by reviewing the theoretical rationales that have been offered for why relations may exist among these variables and performance.

Job Satisfaction and Performance

By far the most common means of testing the happy / productive worker thesis has been by examining the relation between job satisfaction and job performance. More specifically, proponents of the human relations school of management (Perrow, 1986, p. 60) emphasized the supposed need or desire for employees to get along with co-workers and be satisfied with their jobs. Job satisfaction thus came to be considered as a reflection of how desirable or attractive an employee considered their job to be. As a consequence, a number of theories evolved concerned with examining the proposed impact of job satisfaction on such worker-related behaviours as turnover, absenteeism, and tardiness. In addition, even though none of these theories provided a clearly defined theoretical justification for a job satisfaction-performance relation, over time, this supposed happy-productive worker thesis came to be considered as fact by many. However, in actual fact, the net result of a number of

scientific reviews is less clear-cut regarding the supposed utility of the job satisfaction-performance relation. Although some have been skeptical, others have been more optimistic (Brief, 1998).

Dispositional Affect and Performance

At least two broad traits are useful for understanding affect at work: Negative Affectivity (trait-NA) and Positive Affectivity (trait-PA). NA is the disposition to experience negative feelings. High NAs report emotions that are negative, such as “annoyed” and “distressed.” Low NAs tend to experience less of these feelings. For example, a low NA might indicate a tendency to be “serene” or “content.” While high NAs are generally prone to experience distress over time and across situations, low NAs “are less likely to think and behave in ways that promote negative affective experiences” (George, 1996, p. 147).

PA is the disposition to experience positive feelings. High PAs experience a good deal of positive feelings, such as “joyfulness” and “enthusiasm.” High PAs also tend to perceive stimuli and behave in ways to support these positive feelings. At the low end, PA is best characterized by the absence of positive emotions, such as “bored” or “droopy.” As a result, low PAs tend to become somewhat disengaged from the world around them. Furthermore, since NA and PA are considered independent dimensions over time by a number of researchers, an individual can be high on both NA and PA, low on both, or high on one and low on the other. Thus, from this perspective, feelings of happiness are composed of, or at least caused by, two traits rather than one.

NA and PA appear to be useful constructs for understanding psychological reactions to the work context. In this regard, they have considerable merit as predictors of a wide variety of work-related attitudes and indices of work strain. Recent research has also used long-established models of motivation to hypothesize how NA and PA could predict employee achievement or performance (Brief, 1998). From the perspective of expectancy theory, PA could facilitate not only the expectancy that one’s effort leads to performance, but also the belief that performance leads to positive outcomes. The basis for these predictions comes from research showing that PA can lead to greater self-efficacy (Forgas, Bower, & Moylan, 1990) and optimistic biases in the estimation of future events (Seligman, 1991). On the other hand, those high in NA are apt to be less optimistic that their effort will lead to success or that positive outcomes will be forthcoming (Wright & Staw, 1999).

As a result of these considerations, one might expect individuals high on PA to be better performers

than those low in PA. Conversely, those high in NA should be worse performers than those low in NA. However, to date, there is little direct empirical evidence linking NA and PA to performance. The present research was designed to help shed additional light on the possible relation between dispositional affect and performance-related behaviours.

Psychological Well-Being and Performance

The importance of employee psychological well-being (PWB) has long been recognized by organizational scientists. PWB measures the hedonic or pleasantness dimension of individual feelings and is widely conceptualized in terms of the overall effectiveness of an individual’s psychological and social functioning. To that end, PWB captures both positive and negative emotional states on a single axis. The high pole is anchored by such adjectives as “joyous.” The low pole is anchored by such adjectives as “sad” and “annoyed.” Thus, to be high on well-being is to be simultaneously high on positive emotion and low on negative emotion.

Clinical psychologists have long recognized the role of the pleasantness dimension of well-being (i.e., happiness vs. sadness or depression) in the determination of various individual outcomes. For example, depressed individuals tend to have very low self-esteem, be pessimistic, and exhibit reduced motivation and slowed thought processes. PWB is typically considered an affectively based “context-free” or global construct, one which is not tied to any particular situation. PWB tends to be viewed as trait-like, as it shows some consistency across time and over situations (e.g., Diener, 1984).

Like their clinical psychology counterparts, organizational theorists have also long recognized the extensive costs, in both financial and human terms, attributable to employee dysfunctional PWB. More specifically, evidence that PWB is related to employee performance comes from several recent studies. Staw, Sutton, and Pelled (1994) re-analyzed a longitudinal data set to examine whether a single dimension measure of well-being could predict changes in performance outcomes. Staw et al. found support that their measure predicted changes in salary, performance evaluations, and social support. Likewise, Wright and his colleagues also found support for the PWB to performance relation (see Wright & Staw, 1999).

The purpose of the current research was to directly assess the relations of psychological well-being, positive and negative affectivity, and job satisfaction to job performance. To date, no research has examined the relative contribution of job satisfaction, dispositional affect, and PWB, considered together, as correlates of

TABLE 1
Means, Standard Deviations, and Intercorrelations for Study Variables

Variables	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. Employee Well-Being	3.4	1.5	(.70)	.59**	-.62**	.03	.37*	.45**
2. Positive PANAS	3.1	0.6		(.93)	-.47**	.31*	.05	.04
3. Negative PANAS	1.8	0.6			(.89)	-.17	.01	-.20
4. Composite Job Satisfaction	3.2	0.8				(.68)	-.10	.06
5. Time 1 Composite Performance	3.3	0.7					(.81)	.39**
6. Time 2 Composite Performance	3.2	0.6						(.69)

Note. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$. Diagonal entries represent Cronbach alpha reliabilities.

job performance. Given the demonstrated intercorrelations among these variables, coupled with their proposed relation with performance, it is both theoretically and practically relevant to establish the unique contribution of these operationalizations of happiness as correlates of job performance. To that end, we pose the following exploratory research question: What are the relative contributions of job satisfaction, positive affectivity, negative affectivity, and PWB as correlates of job performance?

METHOD

Public-sector management professionals from a governmental county agency on the West Coast of the United States ($N = 59$) were asked by the two junior authors to participate in the study through a direct contact procedure. The actual sample includes original data available from 49 employees, representing a response rate of 83%. All respondents had completed high school, were employed within the same department, and performed the same job duties, which involved various supervisory responsibilities. Measures of job satisfaction, dispositional affect, and psychological well-being were available at T1. Measures of composite job performance were available at T1 and, two years later, at T2.

The eight-item Index of Psychological Well-Being (Berkman, 1971) measured psychological well-being. Sample items include how often the respondent felt: "depressed or very unhappy" and "on top of the world." Positive and negative affectivity were assessed by the PANAS scale developed by Watson, Clark and Tellegen (1988). PA is measured by descriptors such as "active, alert, enthusiastic, and interested." NA is assessed by descriptors such as "afraid, hostile, irritable, and upset." Participants were asked to indicate the extent to which they experienced each positive and negative descriptor of affect *in general* on a 5-point scale ranging from "very slightly or not at all" to "extremely." Three widely recognized dimensions of job satisfaction (degree of satisfaction

with the work itself, degree of satisfaction with co-workers, and degree of satisfaction with supervision) were used to measure job satisfaction. Ratings were made on a 5-point scale ranging from (1) "very unsatisfied" to (5) "very satisfied." These three items were summed to form a composite measure of job satisfaction. Finally, management personnel from the current organization confirmed three dimensions as appropriate and relevant for assessing employee performance: work facilitation, goal emphasis, and team building. Each dimension was measured using a 5-point scale ranging from "never" to "always." The organization's top-ranking administrative officer provided ratings of each employee's work performance for the relevant review period (one year) at Times 1 and 2. The three items were summed to form a composite measure of performance.

RESULTS AND SUMMARY DISCUSSION

The means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations for each of the study measures are reported in Table 1. Although composite job satisfaction, PA, and NA were not associated with composite performance at Times 1 and 2, significant positive relations were obtained between PWB and composite performance at both Time 1 and Time 2.

Although these bivariate results involve longitudinal data, they cannot rule out the possibility that performance ratings may have caused worker happiness. That is, receiving high ratings at Time 1 could have promoted higher PWB. Furthermore, as posed in our exploratory research question, these bivariate results do not provide evidence of the unique contribution of well-being to performance, controlling for composite job satisfaction, NA, and PA. To address this issue, hierarchical regression analysis was performed in which composite performance at Time 2 was regressed on well-being, job satisfaction, NA, PA, and prior composite performance at Time 1. The control variables of composite job satisfaction, NA, PA, and prior composite performance at Time 1 were entered into the equa-

TABLE 2
Hierarchical Regression Predicting Composite Performance at Time 2

Independent Variable	Step 1		Step 2	
	Beta	SE	Beta	SE
Positive Affectivity (PA)	-.01	.05	-.06	.06
Negative Affectivity (NA)	-.04	.06	.03	.06
Composite Job Satisfaction	.12	.50	.08	.46
Composite Performance at Time 1	.30*	.15	.14	.15
Psychological Well-Being	n/a	n/a	.77*	.32
	$R^2 = .15$		$R^2 = .31$	
	Adjusted $R^2 = .02$		Change in $R^2 = .16^*$	
			Adjusted $R^2 = .17$	

* $p < .05$, one-tailed test.

tion simultaneously at Step 1. As shown in Table 2, these variables failed to account for a significant amount of variance in composite performance at Time 2, $F(4,26) = 1.16$, ns. At the second step, all variables (well-being and control) were entered simultaneously, $F(5,25) = 2.21$, ns. The change in R^2 from Step 1 to Step 2 represents the increase in subsequent composite performance variance explained by the study variable, well-being, above and beyond what was accounted for by the control variables. As shown in Table 2, the change in R^2 was 0.16, $t(25) = 2.37$, $p < .05$, indicating that well-being did account for a significant proportion of the variance in composite performance at Time 2 above and beyond that accounted for by the control variables.

The present results supported the hypothesis that psychological well-being is positively related to job performance. A single well-being dimension, anchored at one end by negative and at the other end by positive feelings, proved to be more predictive of performance than the unipolar NA/PA factors used to measure positive and negative dispositional affect. Moreover, these results are consistent with research demonstrating that PWB is a more consistent predictor of performance than various measures of dispositional affect (Wright & Staw, 1999). However, given the modest sample size in the current research, it would be inappropriate at this time to accept the failure to find significant relations among dispositional affectivity, job satisfaction, and job performance without additional research investigations.

The current research is not without methodological limitations. Perhaps the most important source of potential bias concerns our performance measure. It is possible that happy people are simply more pleasant to be around. As such, they receive performance ratings that are biased in a positive direction. Our criteria involved supervisory measures of performance and might be subject to this type of bias. However, it

should be emphasized that neither the dispositionally based measures of PANAS or job satisfaction were associated with job performance. If rating bias accounted for the PWB/job performance relation, then one would also have expected significant bivariate relations among positive affectivity, negative affectivity, job satisfaction, and performance. These were not obtained. Additionally, the longitudinal nature of the research design afforded the opportunity to measure the influence of PWB on the incremental changes in rated performance from Time 1 to Time 2. Thus, a strength of our longitudinal design was the ability to capture any halo contained in the Time 1 performance measure.

We close by emphasizing a large and important issue. This paper was concerned with the well-being/performance relation. However, this should in no way be taken to suggest that performance is the only, or even the most important, reason that well-being is important. It seems to us that promoting happiness is an intrinsic good for which all should work (Wright & Cropanzano, 2000). If it promotes better performance, and our findings agree with a growing body of evidence that suggests that it might, then so much the better. Regardless, well-being remains valuable for its own sake.

A longer report providing a further elaboration of these findings and a complete reference listing is available from the first author, Thomas A. Wright, Managerial Sciences Department, University of Nevada, Reno, Mail Stop 028, Reno, Nevada 89557-0206 (E-mail: taw@unr.nevada.edu).

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